

Depression

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What Is Depression?

Everyone feels sad or low sometimes, but these feelings usually pass. Depression (also called major depression, major depressive disorder, or clinical depression) is different. It can cause severe symptoms that affect how a person feels, thinks, and handles daily activities, such as sleeping, eating, or working.

Depression can affect anyone regardless of age, sex, race or ethnicity, income, culture, or education. Research suggests that genetic, biological, environmental, and psychological factors play a role in the disorder.

Women are diagnosed with depression more often than men, but men can also be depressed. Because men may be less likely to recognize, talk about, and seek help for their negative feelings, they are at greater risk of their depression symptoms being undiagnosed and undertreated. Depression can also co-occur with other mental disorders or chronic illnesses, such as diabetes, cancer, heart disease, and chronic pain, and can make these conditions worse and vice versa.

What Are the Different Types of Depression?

There are two common types of depression:

- Major depression includes symptoms of depressed mood or loss of interest, most of the time for at least 2 weeks, that interfere with daily activities.
- Persistent depressive disorder (also called dysthymia) consists of less severe depression symptoms that last much longer, usually for at least 2 years.

Other types of depression include seasonal affective disorder (comes and goes with the seasons), depression with symptoms of psychosis (a severe form involving delusions or hallucinations), and bipolar disorder (depressive episodes along with manic or hypomanic episodes). Additional types can occur at specific points in a woman's life: premenstrual dysphoric disorder, perinatal depression (during pregnancy or after childbirth), and perimenopausal depression.

What Are the Signs and Symptoms of Depression?

- Persistent sad, anxious, or "empty" mood
- Feelings of hopelessness or pessimism
- Feelings of irritability, frustration, or restlessness
- Feelings of guilt, worthlessness, or helplessness
- Loss of interest or pleasure in hobbies and activities
- Fatigue, lack of energy, or feeling slowed down
- Difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions

- Difficulty sleeping, waking too early, or oversleeping
- Changes in appetite or unplanned weight changes
- Physical aches or pains, headaches, cramps, or digestive problems without a clear cause
- Thoughts of death or suicide, or suicide attempts

Not everyone who is depressed shows all these symptoms; some people experience only a few, while others experience many. If you show signs or symptoms of depression and they persist, talk to a health care provider. If you or someone you know is struggling or having thoughts of suicide, call or text the 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline at 988, or chat at 988lifeline.org. In life-threatening situations, call 911.

How Is Depression Diagnosed?

To be diagnosed with depression, a person must have symptoms most of the day, nearly every day, for at least 2 weeks, including a depressed mood or loss of interest or pleasure in most activities. Children and adolescents may be irritable rather than sad. A health care provider may ask when symptoms began, how long they have lasted, how often they occur, and whether they interfere with usual activities, and may run a physical exam, interview, and lab tests to rule out other causes such as thyroid disorders.

Does Depression Look the Same in Everyone?

Depression can affect people differently depending on their age:

- Children may be anxious or cranky, pretend to be sick, refuse to go to school, cling to a parent, or worry that a parent may die.
- Older children and teens may get into trouble at school, sulk, be easily frustrated, feel restless, or have low self-esteem, and are more likely to experience excessive sleepiness and increased appetite.
- Young adults are more likely to be irritable, complain of weight gain and excess sleep, and have a negative view of life and the future.
- Middle-aged adults may have more depressive episodes, decreased libido, middle-of-the-night insomnia, or early morning waking, and often report stomach problems.
- Older adults often feel sadness, grief, or other less obvious symptoms, and may report a lack of emotions rather than a depressed mood; memory and thinking problems may be prominent in severe cases.

How Is Depression Treated?

Depression treatment typically involves psychotherapy, medication, or both. Choosing the right plan is based on a person's needs, preferences, and medical situation, in consultation with a mental health professional; finding the best treatment may take trial and error.

Psychotherapy

Psychotherapy (talk therapy or counseling) can help people with depression by teaching new ways of thinking and behaving. It can be effective in person or via telehealth. Evidence-based approaches include cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), which helps people challenge and change unhelpful thoughts and

behaviors, and interpersonal therapy (IPT), which focuses on interpersonal and life events that impact mood.

Medication

Antidepressants work by changing how the brain produces or uses certain chemicals involved in mood or stress. They typically take 4–8 weeks to work, and sleep, appetite, and concentration often improve before mood lifts. Treatment-resistant depression occurs when a person doesn't improve after trying at least two antidepressants; options include esketamine (an FDA-approved nasal-spray medication) or combining an antidepressant with another type of medication. All medications can have side effects, and patients of all ages should be watched closely, especially in the first few weeks or after a dose change, for an increase in suicidal thoughts or behavior.

Brain Stimulation Therapy

An option when other treatments have not worked, involving activating or inhibiting the brain with electricity or magnetic waves. The most used approaches are electroconvulsive therapy (ECT) and repetitive transcranial magnetic stimulation (rTMS). It is generally used only after psychotherapy and medication have been tried, and is sometimes used earlier when depression has become life-threatening.

Natural Products

The FDA has not approved any natural products for treating depression. Some people report that vitamin D or the herbal supplement St. John's wort helped their symptoms, but these can carry risks, including interactions with prescription medications — talk to a health care provider before using any supplement.

How Can I Take Care of Myself?

Most people with depression benefit from mental health treatment, and should gradually start to feel better once treatment begins. Other things that may help:

- Try to get physical activity — just 30 minutes a day of walking can boost your mood.
- Try to maintain a regular bedtime and wake-up time.
- Eat regular, healthy meals.
- Do what you can, as you can — decide what must get done and what can wait.
- Connect with people; talk to people you trust about how you are feeling.
- Delay important life decisions until you feel better; discuss decisions with people who know you well.
- Avoid using alcohol, nicotine, or drugs, including medications not prescribed for you.

How Can I Find Help for Depression?

The Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) has an online tool to help you find mental health services in your area at findtreatment.gov. If you or someone you know is struggling or having thoughts of suicide, call or text 988 (the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline) or chat at 988lifeline.org.

How Can I Help a Loved One Who Is Depressed?

- Offer support, understanding, patience, and encouragement.
- Invite them out for walks, outings, and other activities.
- Help them stick to their treatment plan, such as setting reminders to take prescribed medications.
- Make sure they have transportation or access to therapy appointments.
- Remind them that, with time and treatment, their depression can lift.

For More Information

Learn more about mental health disorders and topics at the NIMH website (www.nimh.nih.gov) or the National Library of Medicine's MedlinePlus (medlineplus.gov).

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